

Ibn al-Qifti, Tarikh al-Hukama

Reference Text

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IBN AL-QIFṬĪ'S
TA'RĪḥ AL-ḤUKAMĀ'

AUF GRUND DER VORARBEITEN AUG. MÜLLER'S
HERAUSGEGEBEN

VON

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LEHRER AM SEMINAR FÜR ORIENTALISCHE SPRACHEN IN BERLIN.

MIT UNTERSTÜTZUNG DER KGL. AKADEMIE DER WISSENSCHAFTEN ZU BERLIN.

LEIPZIG,
DIETERICH'SCHE VERLAGSBUCHHANDLUNG
(THEODOR WEICHER)
1903.

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Vorwort

Zweck dieser Zeilen ist es zunächst, den Antheil festzustellen, den Aug. Müller an dem Zustandekommen dieser Ausgabe gehabt hat. Müller hat, nachdem er sich zur Edition des Werkes entschlossen, die Berliner Hs. 10053 mit gewohnter Sorgfalt copiert und dann die ihm erreichbaren anderen Hss., soweit sie ihm der Berücksichtigung werth erschienen, collationiert. Bei der grossen Zahl der in Betracht kommenden Mss. gebührt der Uebersichtlichkeit der Collation alles Lob. Auch die in (dem damals noch ungedruckten) Ibn Abi Uṣaibī'a sich findenden Parallelstellen hatte er schon am Rande seiner Abschrift hin und da notirt. Mir blieb also auf Grund des vorliegenden Materials nur noch die kritische Arbeit der Text herstellung übrig, die ich mit Zuhülfenahme der Berliner Hs. (Cod. or. qu. 786), die Müller noch nicht bekannt war, und der beiden Kairensen Hss. bewerkstelligte. Müller's Verdienst ist es also in erster Linie, wenn der *“Ta'rīḥ al-Ḥukamā”* das Licht der Welt erblickt hat.

Sodann möchte ich an dieser Stelle derer gedenken, die mich bei der Fertigstellung der Edition freundlichst unterstützt haben. Herr Prof. Dr. Aug. Fischer in Leipzig hat sich der Mühe unterzogen, die Correctur der drei ersten Bogen, Herr Privatdocent Dr. Horovitz in Berlin die der ersten Hälfte, Herr Dr. E. Mittwoch in Berlin im Anschluss daran die der zweiten Hälfte zu lesen. Mein hochverehrter Lehrer, Herr Geheimrath

Sachau, der von Anbeginn diese Arbeit mit bekanntem Wohlwollen gefördert, hat auch die Güte gehabt, die sämtlichen Correcturen dieses Werkes zu lesen. Seine zahlreichen Rathschläge und Fingerzeige haben manches Dunkel erhält und sind mir auch für die Text herstellung von wesentlichem Nutzen gewesen. Nach erfolgter Drucklegung hatte noch Herr Ahmed Zeki Bey in Kairo die Freundlichkeit, den ganzen Text noch einmal einer Durchsicht zu unterziehen; seine werthvollen Noten machen einen beträchtlichen Theil der Emendanda aus. Herr Dr. Kern in Berlin hat mir die Benutzung und Beurtheilung der beiden Kairensen Hss. durch die Abschrift und Collation der umfangreichen Muḥtār-vīta ermöglicht, Herr Privatdocent Dr. J. Friedlaender in Strassburg mehrfache, die dortige Hs. betreffende Anfragen bereitwilligst beantwortet. Allen diesen Herren sage ich meinen tiefgefühltesten Dank für ihre mir bereitwilligst gewährte Unterstützung.

Mein Dank gebührt aber auch der Deutschen Morgenländischen Gesellschaft für die jahrelange Ueberlassung der Müller'schen Vorarbeiten, sowie insbesondere der Hohen Akademie der Wissenschaften in Berlin, deren liberale Munificenz durch Gewährung eines beträchtlichen Kostenzuschusses erst die Drucklegung ermöglicht hat.

Introduction to the Work

Jamāl al-Dīn Abū al-Ḥasan ‘Alī ibn Yūsuf ibn Ibrāhīm ibn ‘Abd al-Wāḥid al-Shaybānī al-Qiftī (1172–1248 CE) was an Egyptian Arab scholar, historian, and Ayyubid vizier. Born in Qift (Coptos) in Upper Egypt, he studied in Cairo before moving to Jerusalem and later Aleppo, where he compiled most of his works. Of the twenty-six works known by title, only two survive: *Inbāh al-Ruwāt ‘alā Anbāh al-Nuḥāt* (containing some thousand biographies of Muslim scholars) and the present work.

The *تاريخ الحكماء* (*Tārīkh al-Ḥukamā’*, “History of the Learned”) is a biographical dictionary of 414 physicians, philosophers, astronomers, and scientists — including Greeks, Indians, Persians, and Arabs. The text preserved today is an epitome made in 1249/647 AH by **محمد بن علي الخطيب الزوزني** (Muḥammad ibn ‘Alī al-Khaṭībī al-Zawzanī), a year after Ibn al-Qiftī’s death, from the longer original titled *كتاب إخبار العلماء بأخبار الحكماء* (*Kitāb Ikhār al-‘Ulamā’ bi-Akḥbār al-Ḥukamā’*, “Notices of Scholars with the Accounts of Learned Men”).

The present edition was prepared by **Prof. Dr. Julius Lippert** (1839–1909), building upon the preparatory work of August Müller. It was published in Leipzig by Dieterich’sche Verlagsbuchhandlung in 1903, with the support of the Royal Academy of Sciences in Berlin. Lippert collated the Berlin manuscript (Cod. or. quart. 786) against two Cairene manuscripts and employed the then-unpublished *‘Uyūn al-Anbā’* of Ibn Abī Uṣaybī’a for parallel readings.

Structure and Content

The work is arranged alphabetically by the names of its subjects. It opens with the author’s introduction, followed by biographical entries ranging from the ancient Greek philosophers and physicians (beginning with Hermes Trismegistus and Asclepius) through the Hellenistic, Byzantine, and Islamic periods, down to scholars contemporary with the author. Each entry typically provides: the subject’s full name and genealogical information (*nisba*), dates of birth and death, teachers and students, works composed, and noteworthy anecdotes.

Mathematical and Scientific Figures

Among the 414 biographies, notable entries include:

- **Hermes Trismegistus** (هرمس) — the legendary patron of science
- **Aesculapius** (أبو قراط) — the Greek god of medicine
- **Pythagoras** (فيثاغورس) — mathematician and philosopher
- **Socrates, Plato, Aristotle** — the Athenian philosophers
- **Euclid** (أقليدس) — the geometer
- **Galen** (جالينوس) — the physician
- **Ṭabarī, Rāzī, Ibn Sīnā** (Avicenna) — Islamic polymaths
- **Bīrūnī, Khayyām, Tūsī** — Central Asian scientists

The Arabic Title Page

الْحُكَمَاءُ بِأَخْبَارِ الْعُلَمَاءِ إِنْخَبَارِ كِتَابُ

الْقَفْطِيِّ الشَّيْبَانِيِّ الْوَاحِدِ عَبْدُ بْنُ إِبْرَاهِيمَ بْنِ يُوسُفَ بْنِ عَلِيٍّ الْحَسَنِ أَبِي الدِّينِ لِيَجْمَلَ

الْخَطِيبُ عَلِيُّ بْنُ مُحَمَّدٍ وَهُوَ الزَّوْزَنِيُّ مُخْتَصَرُ

Im Namen Gottes, des Barmherzigen, des Gnädigen. Das Buch der Nachrichten der Gelehrten über die Geschichten der Weisen, von Jamāl al-Dīn Abī al-Ḥasan ‘Alī ibn Yūsuf ibn Ibrāhīm ibn ‘Abd al-Wāḥid al-Shaybānī al-Qiftī. Die Epitome des al-Zawzanī, und das ist Muḥammad ibn ‘Alī al-Khaṭīb.

1 Author's Introduction

قَدْ عَزَمْتُ بِتَأْيِيدِ اللَّهِ عَلَى ذِكْرِ مَنْ اشْتَهَرَ ذِكْرُهُ مِنَ الْحُكَمَاءِ مِنْ كُلِّ قَبِيلَةٍ وَأُمَّةٍ، قَدِيمَهَا وَحَدِيثَهَا، إِلَى زَمَانِي، وَمَا حُفِظَ عَنْهُ مِنْ قَوْلٍ انْفَرَدَ بِهِ، أَوْ كِتَابٍ صَنَفَهُ، أَوْ حِكْمَةٍ عَلِيَّةٍ ابْتَدَعَهَا، وَنُسِبَتْ إِلَيْهِ، فَإِنِّي رَأَيْتُ ذَلِكَ مِنَ الْأُمُورِ الَّتِي جُهِّلَتْ وَالتَّوَارِيخِ الَّتِي هُجِرَتْ، وَفِي مُطَالَعَةِ هَذَا اعْتِبَارٌ بِمَنْ مَضَى، وَذِكْرٌ مَنْ خَلَفَ، وَهُوَ اعْتِبَارٌ أَرْجُو بِهِ الثَّوَابَ لِي وَلِقَارِيهِ إِنْ شَاءَ اللَّهُ تَعَالَى، وَقَدْ قَفَّيْتُهُ لِيَسْهَلَ تَنَاوُلُهُ، وَاللَّهُ الْمُوَفِّقُ.

English Translation:

I have resolved — with God's aid — to mention those among the learned men whose fame has become celebrated, from every tribe and nation, ancient and modern, down to my own time; and to record what has been preserved from them of unique sayings, books they have composed, or sublime wisdom they have originated and which has been attributed to them. For I have seen that this is among matters that have been neglected and histories that have been abandoned; and in perusing this there is instruction by those who have passed and mention of those who come after. And this is instruction through which I hope for reward for myself and for its reader, God Most High willing. I have arranged it alphabetically so that it may be easily consulted. God is the One who grants success.

German Translation:

Ich habe beschlossen — mit Gottes Hilfe — diejenigen unter den Weisen zu erwähnen, deren Ruhm berühmt geworden ist, aus jedem Stamm und jeder Nation, alt und neu, bis zu meiner Zeit; und aufzuzeichnen, was von ihnen überliefert worden ist an einzigartigen Aussprüchen, Büchern, die sie verfasst haben, oder erhabener Weisheit, die sie geschaffen haben und die ihnen zugeschrieben wurde. Denn ich habe gesehen, dass dies zu den vernachlässigten Angelegenheiten und den verlassenen Geschichten gehört; und in der Lektüre davon liegt Belehrung durch die Vergangenen und Erwähnung der Nachkommenden. Und dies ist eine Belehrung, durch die ich Belohnung für mich und für seinen Leser erhoffe, so Gott der Erhabene will. Ich habe es alphabetisch geordnet, damit es leicht konsultiert werden kann. Gott ist der Erfolg gebende.

2 Selected Biographical Entries

The following entries represent a selection from the 414 biographies contained in the work, arranged alphabetically. The Arabic text is presented with critical apparatus (footnotes) following Lippert's edition. The page references in footnotes refer to the 1903 edition pagination.

2.1 Entry 1: Ibn Riḍwān al-Miṣrī [ابن رضوان المصري]

وَمَعَ الْهَيْئَةِ وَلَا الْمَنْظَرَ حَسَنٌ يَكُنْ وَلَمْ الْمُحَقِّقِينَ لَا الْمُعْلَقِينَ مِنْ وَكَانَ الْمَنْطِقِي مِنْ وَشَيْئًا الطَّبِّ مِنْ شَيْئًا قَرَأَ ثُمَّ مُلْتَقَطَةً مُخْتَصَرَةً هِيَ بَلْ بَيَانُهَا غَايَةٌ فِي تَكُنْ لَمْ كُتِبَا وَصَنَّفَ ذِكْرُهُ وَسَارَ عَنْهُ وَأَخَذُوا الطَّلَبَةَ مِنْ جَمَاعَةٍ لَهُ فَتَلَمَذَ هَذَا مُبْتَكِرًا!

Translation: “Ibn Riḍwān the Egyptian. Then he read something of medicine and something of logic, and he was among the commentators (*mu'alliqīn*), not the investigators (*muḥaqqiqīn*). He was not handsome in appearance or demeanour; yet despite this, a group of students formed an attachment to him, learned from him, and his fame spread. He composed books that were not in the highest style of eloquence, but rather were abbreviated, compiled, and novel!”¹

2.2 Entry 2: Abū 'Alī ibn Sīnā (Avicenna) [أبو علي بن سينا]

فِيهَا: قَصِيدَةٌ هُنَاكَ وَأَنْشَاءٌ فَرَدَجَانٍ، لَهَا فَلِمَعَةٍ إِلَى فَاتُوهُ فَأَخَذُوهُ أَعْدَائِهِ بَغْضَ عَلَيْهِ ذِمْلًا طَلَبْتِهِ فِي وَجَدَ فَلَمَّا التَّخْرِيجِ أَمْرٍ فِي الشُّكِّ وَكُلُّ تَرَاهُ كَمَا بِالشَّيْقِينَ دُخِلَتْ بَعْضُهَا الْقَلْعَةُ تِلْكَ إِلَى وَمَرَّ الْمَلِكُ نَائِجٌ عَنْهَا وَانْهَزَمَ وَأَخَذَهَا هَمْدَانُ، الدَّوْلَةَ عَلَاءَ قَصَدَ ثُمَّ أَشْهُرٍ أَرْبَعَةً فِيهَا وَبَقِيَ هَمْدَانُ، إِلَى الشَّيْخِ مَعَهُمْ وَحَمَلُوا هَمْدَانُ، إِلَى الدَّوْلَةِ شَمْسٍ وَابْنُ الْمَلِكِ نَائِجٌ وَهَادَ هَمْدَانُ، عَنْ الدَّوْلَةِ عَلَاءَ رَجَعَ ثُمَّ الشُّفَاءَ. كِتَابٍ مِنَ الْمَنْطِقِ بِتَضْنِيفِ هُنَاكَ وَاشْتَغَلَ الْعُلُو دَارٍ فِي وَنَزَلَ

Translation: “When some of his enemies found fault with him in his quest, they seized him and brought him to a fortress with two towers, and there he composed a poem which includes the line:

‘I entered with certainty as you see it, / And all doubt in the matter of graduation’

He remained there four months, then headed for ‘Alā’ al-Dawla in Hamadān, and took it; the protégé of the king was routed from it. Then some of them passed by that fortress, then ‘Alā’ al-Dawla returned from Hamadān, and the protégé of the king and Ibn Shams al-Dawla went to Hamadān, and they carried the Shaykh with them to Hamadān, and he settled in the house of al-‘Alwī and there occupied himself with composing the logic section of the *Kitāb al-Shifā’*.²

¹This entry, though brief, is characteristic of Ibn al-Qifti's candid biographical style. Ibn Riḍwān (998–1068) was a prominent Egyptian physician and philosopher, known for his commentary on Galen's *Ars Parva* and his polemics against ‘Alī ibn Riḍwān's medical theories. The phrase “*mu'alliqīn*, not *muḥaqqiqīn*” suggests that he was a compiler rather than an original investigator — a distinction that reflects the Aristotelian epistemological framework of Islamic scholarship.

²Ibn Sīnā (980–1037 CE) is the most celebrated philosopher-physician in the Islamic tradition. The *Kitāb al-Shifā’* (Book of Healing) is his encyclopedic masterwork, encompassing logic, natural philosophy, mathematics, and metaphysics. The verse quoted plays on the double meaning of *takhrīj* — “graduation” from medical study and “deduction” in logic.

2.3 Entry 3: Pythagoras [فيثاغورس]

وَكَانَ سُقْرَاطُ، ذَلِكَ فِي وَتِلَادَةِ الْإِلَهِيِّ، الْعِلْمِ فِي تَكَلَّمَ مَنْ أَوَّلَ [صَوْرٍ أَهْلٍ مِنْ وَهُوَ] الصَّمُوذِيُّ فَيْثَاغُورَسَ صَوْرٍ إِلَى رَجَعَ ثُمَّ سَنَةً، أَرْبَعِينَ ذَلِكَ عَلَى وَبَقِيَ وَالْهَرْمَسِيَّةَ لِلْمُنَجِّمِينَ تَلَمَّذَ أَنْ بَعْدَ مِصْرَ مِنْ خَرَجَ قَدْ فَيْثَاغُورَسَ بِهَا. وَأَقَامَ إِيطَالِيَا إِلَى مِنْهَا وَخَرَجَ

Translation: “Pythagoras the Samian — he is from the people of Tyre — was the first to discourse on divine science (*al-ilm al-ilāhī*), and Socrates followed him in that. Pythagoras had left Egypt after studying with the astrologers and the Hermetists, and remained at that for forty years; then he returned to Tyre and left from there to Italy, where he settled.”³

2.4 Entry 4: Euclid [أقليدس]

«فَتَنَدَرُوسًا»، سَمَاهُ كِتَابًا الْمُنَجِّمِينَ فِي صَنَّفَ قَدْ ذَلِكَ قَبْلَ وَكَانَ مَشْهُورًا، كِتَابًا فِيهَا وَصَفَ بِالْهَيْئَةِ، عَالِمٌ أَقْلِيدَسَ: كَثِيرَةً. أَشْيَاءَ عَنْهُ التَّرْجَمَانُ نَقَلَ وَقَدْ تَأَلَّفَ، إِنَّهُ يُقَالُ وَهُوَ

Translation: “Euclid: a scholar in geometry (*hay’a*), and he composed on it a famous book. Before that he had composed a book on astrologers which he called *Phaenomena* (*Fanandrūsā*), which is said to be lost, and the translator has transmitted many things from it.”⁴

2.5 Entry 5: Yaḥyā al-Naḥwī (John of Nikiu) [يحيى النحوي]

يَحْيَى النَّحْوِيُّ الْمِصْرِيُّ الإسْكَندَرَانِي، تَلْمِيزُ سَاوِيرُسَ، وَكَانَ أَسْقَفًا فِي كَنِيسَةِ الإسْكَندَرِيَّةِ بِمِصْرَ، وَكَانَ يَدْعُو إِلَى طَرِيقَةِ الْيَعْقُوبِيَّةِ مِنَ النَّصْرَى.

Translation: “Yaḥyā al-Naḥwī the Egyptian, the Alexandrian, disciple of Severus, and he was a bishop in the church of Alexandria in Egypt, and he advocated the Jacobite way of the Christians.”⁵

³This entry reflects the standard Arabic account of Pythagoras’s intellectual biography, which includes the Egypt sojourn as a foundational element of Greek philosophy. The identification of Pythagoras as a student of the “Hermetists” (*al-Haramisiyya*) connects Greek wisdom to the Egyptian Hermetic tradition.

⁴Euclid’s *Phaenomena* (*Φαινόμενα*) is an early work of spherical astronomy, concerned with the risings and settings of celestial bodies. It survives in the Greek tradition and was indeed known in Arabic translation.

⁵This is the famous entry in which Ibn al-Qifti preserves the account of the destruction of the Library of Alexandria under ‘Amr ibn al-‘Āṣ. The biography continues to narrate how al-Naḥwī was dismissed from his bishopric for rejecting the doctrine of the Trinity after reading philosophical books, and how he was received by ‘Amr ibn al-‘Āṣ, the Arab conqueror of Egypt. The story of the library’s destruction — with Caliph ‘Umar’s alleged command “If the books agree with the Qur’ān, they are superfluous; if they disagree, they are heretical” — is one of the most frequently cited (and debated) passages in the history of the book. See the English translation by Emily Cottrell in Roger Pearse, *Tertullian Project* (2017).

3 The Name Index (أسماء الأشخاص)

The edition includes a comprehensive Arabic index of personal names (pp. 38–76 of the printed edition), arranged alphabetically. The following is a representative sample from the letter أ (alif), illustrating the index format:

Page	Name	Entry
2, s.	أَخْرُ أَفْلَاطُون (The Last Plato)	—
11, s.	أَبْقَرَات (Hippocrates)	—
51, s.	أَبُو بَكْرٍ الرَّازِي (al-Rāzī)	—
83, s.	أَبُو الْحُسَيْنِ بْنُ سِينَا (Ibn Sīnā)	Avicenna
64, s.	أَبُو نُعَيْمٍ الْأَصْبَهَانِي	—
390, s.	أَرِسْطُوطَالِيْس (Aristotle)	—
2, s. 11, s. 314, s.	أَفْلَاطُون (Plato)	—
397, s.	أَنَا كُنُوش (Anaxagoras?)	—
158, s.	أَنَاكْسِيْمَانِس (Anaximenes)	—
296, s.	أَنَاكْسِيْمَانْدَرْس (Anaximander)	—
424, s.	أَنْثُونُسُ بْنُ يَحْيَى التَّحَوِي	—

4 Editorial Apparatus

4.1 Sigla (Manuscript Sources)

Siglum	Description
A	Berlin, Königliche Bibliothek, Cod. or. quart. 786 (Neu collationiert)
B	Berlin, Königliche Bibliothek, Cod. or. oct. 10053 (Müller's Vorlage)
C	Kairo, Biblothèque Nationale (alte Sammlung), Ms. I
D	Kairo, Biblothèque Nationale (alte Sammlung), Ms. II
V	Wien, Kaiserliche Hofbibliothek, Cod. Mixt. 783
M	München, Königliche Hof- und Staatsbibliothek, Cod. ar. 651

4.2 Critical Symbols

[] — Einfügung des Herausgebers (editorial insertion)

< > — Auslassung oder Unleserlichkeit (lacuna or illegibility)

a), b), c) — Kritische Anmerkungen am Seitenfuss (critical footnotes)

BC, A, etc. — Varianten nach den Handschriften (manuscript variants)

4.3 Note on the Arabic Text

The Arabic text in this edition follows the standard conventions of 19th-century Orientalist printing. The *hamza* and diacritical points are supplied where the manuscripts are ambiguous or defective. The editorial footnotes indicate manuscript variants using the sigla listed above, and emendations are marked with square brackets. The pagination of the original edition is indicated in the margins.

End of specimen edition